

➤ **SoftLang Seminar : Palantir Gotham and the Attributes of Contemporary Mass Surveillance**

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Motivation: From Isolated Tools to an Integrated Platform

- Surveillance has Shifted:

From single-purpose tools (wiretaps, cameras, radar) to integrated data-processing platforms that combine heterogeneous sources at scale.

- Recurring attributes of Mass Surveillance :

- i. Large-scale (bulk) data collection
- ii. Integration of heterogeneous / third-party sources
- iii. Storage for later (retrospective) analysis

- Technical Accounts vs. Surveillance Attributes :

Platforms like Palantir Gotham are documented in technical terms - connectors, ontology, versioning rather than explicitly in terms of these surveillance attributes.

- Gap:

The technical account of the platform and the attribute account of surveillance have rarely been systematically connected

RESEARCH QUESTION

RQ → How do the capabilities of Palantir Gotham correspond to three core attributes of contemporary mass surveillance, bulk data collection, integration of heterogeneous data sources, and long-term storage for retrospective analysis as described in the literature?

Why interesting? → Gotham is described technically and surveillance is defined behaviourally / legally. The two are rarely connected in literature reviewed.

Why answer not obvious or a survey otherwise worthwhile? → Correspondence can be partial: a platform may match some attributes and not others.

Why answerable? → Gotham is unusually well documented: vendor materials, patents, and real deployments (e.g. POL-INTEL in Denmark, hessenDATA in Germany).

Underlying hypothesis → Gotham will show a strong correspondence to the next-generation mass-surveillance profile that Underwood & Saiedian (2021) predicted.

Methodology

- **Review type:** Semi-systematic / narrative review (Snyder 2019)
 - **Why this type:** A fully systematic (PRISMA-style) review needs an exhaustive search to capture all evidence. This is mismatched to my cross-disciplinary question. Narrative review maps themes across diverse literatures.
 - **Reporting:** Search & selection documented per van Wee & Banister (2024): databases, keywords, snowballing, selection decisions, document overview.
 - **Synthesis:** Synthesis matrix (Ramdhani et al. 2014) realised as a correspondence table mapping each paper to the three attributes.
- **Process :** design → search & select → analyse/synthesise → write
 - **Downscaling :** seed papers + snowballing instead of exhaustive database search
 - Small corpus (**7 papers**)
 - Scoped to only **3** surveillance attributes (Underwood 2021)

Methodology (1): Search & Selection

- **Seed Papers** (given): Wei et al. 2024 · Underwood & Saiedian 2021 · Schuster et al. 2017
- **Tools:** Google Scholar , Connected Papers (citation-graph) ·
- **Search terms used:** “ontology gotham”, “ mass surveillance metadata” ,”palantir gotham”
- **Snowballing:** "ontology Gotham" in Scholar → **Galis & Karlsson 2024** (top hit) → its Connected Papers graph → **Iliadis & Acker 2022 , Ulbricht & Egbert 2024**
- **Selection criteria:**
 - Kept: peer-reviewed | English | describes Gotham or a Gotham deployment, or defines surveillance in attribute terms
 - Ruled out: journalism / vendor marketing · Palantir-as-company (contracts,politics, finance) with no platform capability detail

Methodology (2): Analysis & Data Extracted

Paper	What I extracted	Example phrase to search (≈page)
Underwood & Saiedian 2021 (Seed Paper)	18-attribute model. the definition of mass surveillance; attribute #10 "third party"; attribute #12 "for future use"	We propose a set of 18 attributes" · "Help from third party" · "For future use if desired" (page 14)
Ni Loideain 2015	indiscriminate bulk (no differentiation); = retention ≤2 yr	"without any differentiation, limitation or exception" · "for up to two years" (page3, 5)
Schuster et al. 2017 (Seed Paper)	National retention range ;indiscriminate.	"structured and unstructured data from different sources" (page 2) · "between 6 and 24 months" (page 5)
Wei et al. 2024 (Seed Paper)	Gotham features: 200+ connectors, dynamic ontology, revisioning DB, investigation repository.	"over 200 data connectors" (page 5) · "dynamic ontology" (page 1–3)
Iliadis & Acker 2022	Patent analysis: integration/storage/provenance topics. nuance: integrates, does not collect; "dragnet".	"Palantir does not collect information directly" · (page 10) "dragnet surveillance" (page 9)
Galis & Karlsson 2024	POL-INTEL: whole-population reach; twelve databases; prognoses from past data.	"vast amounts of data on every single citizen in Denmark" (page 3) · "twelve" databases(page 3)
Ulbricht & Egbert 2024	hessenDATA: "dragnet"; 2-year deletion rule.	"works as a "dragnet" (page7) · "deleted after two years" (page 9) ·

Methodology (3): Limitations

- **Scope:** 3 attributes from Underwood's broader set (bulk, heterogeneous/third-party, storage for future use) – deliberate, but a partial view of 'mass surveillance'
- **Small corpus (7):** not exhaustive ,Semi-systematic Literature review, not systematic; risk of missed papers
- **Citation graph** time-dependent . Neighbourhood may change over time.
- **Single Coder :**All attribute judgements by one reviewer

Findings (1): Attribute–Capability Correspondence Matrix

- Gotham corresponds ***strongly*** to 2) Integration of heterogeneous / third-party sources and 3) Storage for retrospective analysis and ***partially*** 1) Bulk data collection.

Attribute	Definition source	Gotham evidence (key feature)
Bulk collection	Underwood 2021; Ni Loideain 2015; Schuster 2017	Integrates pre-existing bulk data, Does not collect
Heterogeneous / third-party integration	Underwood 2021 ;Schuster 2017; Iliadis & Acker 2022	Dynamic ontology and cross-source resolution; multiple named databases in DK (POL-INTEL) and cross-database links in DE (POLAS, crime, other sources).
Storage for retrospective analysis	Underwood 2021 (#12); Ni Loideain 2015	Revisioning DB, investigation repository, persistent search; 2-yr retention in deployment

Findings (2): Answering the Research Question

- **Bulk collection (Partial):** Does not collect ; it integrates and makes searchable bulk data others collected. Processes data on essentially every citizen in Denmark
- **Heterogeneous integration (Strongest):** Confirmed across vendor docs (Wei), patents (Iliadis & Acker), and two live deployments (DK, DE).
- **Storage for retrospective analysis (Present but legally capped):** Revisioning database and investigation repository support retrospective search; regulated deployments enforce 2-year deletion, matching Ni Loideain's retention criteria.
- **My own interpretation** → “Gotham is an enabler, not a collector”.

Future Work

- **Extend the attribute set:** map Gotham against *all* of Underwood's (2021) attributes, not the 3 scoped here.
- **Add platforms / comparison:** apply the same matrix to other systems (e.g. Foundry, or non-Palantir analytics)
- Seed for a thesis or follow-up seminar

GenAI Usage Declaration

- **Entirely my own (No GenAI):** Topic, research question, choice of the 3 attributes, methodology design, paper search & selection, the analysis, and the correspondence coding.
- **GenAI for comprehension:** Perplexity used to summarize papers *for my own understanding* and to clarify technical terms (e.g., "ontology").
- **GenAI for writing:** an LLM assistant and Perplexity used for paraphrasing, grammar/clarity fixes, and restructuring wording for slide readability , not for framing, analysis, or selection
- Artifacts:
<https://github.com/debiprasad21/Seminar_Mass_Surveillance_Palantir-Gotham>



➤ THANK YOU



➤ Any Questions?

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